

BEYOND THE CREST

Episode #0001

"The Crown on the Hill" (working title)

Production Code BTC-S01-0001

Air Date: MONDAY, JANUARY 5, 2026

Season 1

PRODUCTION DRAFT

Beyond the Crest Writers' Room

CAST

Ages as of Monday, January 5, 2026

CHARACTER	AGE	ROLE
MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK	34	Heir Apparent; President & COO; SECRET Boss of Blackwater
VICTOR DONOHUE	79	Chairman, The Donohue Company
JOAN DONOHUE	77	Philanthropist; Chair, The Donohue Foundation
NATASHA BULLOCK	54	CEO, The Donohue Company
ROBERT BULLOCK	56	Founder, Bullock & Associates, LLP
JASMINE OLSON	55	U.S. Representative for Georgia
DR. PETER OLSON	56	Chief of Plastic Surgery
ELXA JACKSON	35	Chief of Police, APD
DET. JEREMY JACKSON	35	Senior Detective, APD Homicide
GRACE BULLOCK	31	Actress & singer; co-founder, HEIRLOOM
MARTIN OLSON	34	President, Donohue Broadcasting Group
MALLORY OLSON	30	Office manager; co-founder, HEIRLOOM
AMOND BAKER	33	Marc's best friend; SECRET Underboss, Blackwater
ARIANNA CUMMINGS	33	Attorney General of Georgia
ESTHER SMILLEY	33	President & COO, Smilley Corporation; designated heir
HARMONY DIVINE	33	Aspiring filmmaker; SECRETLY "The Tea Kettle ATL"
LYRIC SOLACE BAKER	13	Working actress; Marc's goddaughter & ward
DET. ROSA DELGADO	37	Jeremy's partner, APD Homicide
WINSTON ODUYA	75	Majordomo of Summit House
THE MAN IN THE RIVER	–	Unidentified body (T-Bone Gaines)
MALIK FREEMAN	30	Head bartender, Belmont Crest Country Club
EMMA SMILLEY	13	Elder twin; Marc's secret daughter
VICTORIA SMILLEY	13	Younger twin; Marc's secret daughter
KANE MITCHELL	35	Marc's bodyguard; Blackwater enforcer

Also: rower, patrol officers, dive team, photographers, DBC camera crew, waiters, valets, 500 gala guests, string quartet, jazz band.

SETS

EXT. CHATTAHOOCHEE RIVER - BENEATH THE PACES FERRY ROAD
BRIDGE

INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S ESTATE - KITCHEN

INT. SUMMIT HOUSE - VICTOR'S STUDY

INT. OLSON ESTATE - BREAKFAST ROOM

INT. APD HEADQUARTERS - CHIEF'S OFFICE

EXT. SMILLEY ESTATE - TUXEDO PARK - ESTHER'S TERRACE

INT. DONOHUE TOWER - NATASHA'S OFFICE

INT. BELMONT CREST COUNTRY CLUB - THE VAULT

INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S ESTATE - LYRIC'S ROOM

INT. OLSON ESTATE - MARTIN'S DRESSING ROOM

EXT. SUMMIT HOUSE - MOTOR COURT

INT. SUMMIT HOUSE - GRAND FOYER

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - ESTHER'S BEDROOM

INT. SUMMIT HOUSE - BALLROOM

INT. SUMMIT HOUSE - LIBRARY

EXT. SUMMIT HOUSE - TERRACE

INT. SUMMIT HOUSE - SERVICE CORRIDOR

INT. SUMMIT HOUSE - POWDER ROOM

INT. HARMONY'S APARTMENT - ADAMSVILLE

INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S ESTATE - STUDY

26 scenes

TEASER**1. EXT. CHATTAHOOCHEE RIVER - BENEATH THE PACES FERRY ROAD BRIDGE - DAWN (MON 1/5/26, 6:10 AM)**

Fog lies on the black water like a sheet over a body. Somewhere upstream, a lone ROWER in a single scull cuts through the gray, breath smoking in the January cold.

The oar strikes something soft. The rower looks down.

A MAN floats face-down in the shallows, snagged on a fallen branch. Expensive camel coat. One shoe missing.

The rower's scream echoes off the concrete underbelly of the bridge.

SMASH CUT TO:

LATER. 6:41 AM.

Blue lights strobe through the fog. Yellow tape snaps in the wind. PATROL OFFICERS work the scene. A dive team hauls the body onto the bank.

DET. JEREMY JACKSON (35, looks late 20s; pressed overcoat, polished shoes already ruined by the mud) kneels beside the body with a flashlight. He is careful. He is always careful.

DET. ROSA DELGADO (37, Bronx-born, coffee in one hand, attitude in the other) slides down the embankment behind him.

ROSA

Six in the morning, thirty-one degrees, and a dead man in a two-thousand-dollar coat. Happy New Year, Jackson.

JEREMY

It's the fifth.

ROSA

It's still new to me.

Jeremy angles the flashlight at the man's neck. Dark bruises ring the throat.

JEREMY

Look at this. Finger marks. Thumbs here, and here.

ROSA

Somebody choked him out.

JEREMY

(quiet)

Somebody did this with their bare hands. Close enough to smell his breath.

Rosa checks the coat pockets. Empty. She checks the inside pocket. Empty.

ROSA

No wallet. No phone. No keys. Either he got robbed or somebody wanted him to be nobody.

Headlights sweep across the bank. A black Chevy Tahoe with city plates rolls to a stop at the top of the embankment. The officers straighten up.

ROSA (CONT'D)

(under her breath)

Look alive. Mom's home.

The door opens. CHIEF ELXA JACKSON (35, looks mid-20s; four stars on her collar, long wool coat, no hat, no fear) steps out into the cold and comes down the bank like she owns it. She does.

ELXA

Detective Jackson.

JEREMY

Chief Jackson.

A beat. Even here, even now, a flicker of a private smile between husband and wife.

ELXA

Tell me something good.

JEREMY

Male, Black, forties. Strangled, probably last night. No ID. Somebody walked him down here, or dumped him upstream and let the river do the rest.

ELXA

Upstream.

She turns and looks north, up the river, past the bridge, to where the tree line climbs a dark ridge. Far above the fog, a few lights still glow in the great houses at the top.

Belmont Crest.

ROSA

Upstream is a lot of real estate, Chief.

ELXA

Upstream is my family.

She holds that look a moment too long. Jeremy notices.

JEREMY

Elxa.

ELXA

(snapping back)

I want the M.E. on this in an hour, not a day. I want prints, dental, tattoos, everything. And I want it quiet.

JEREMY

Quiet or by the book?

ELXA

Both.

JEREMY

Those don't always go together.

ELXA

Then pick the one that keeps my phone
from ringing.

She starts back up the embankment, then stops.

ELXA (CONT'D)

And Jeremy. Eight o'clock. Summit
House. You are wearing the tux.

JEREMY

There's a body on the riverbank.

ELXA

It's my brother's birthday. The body
will still be dead at midnight.

She climbs back to the Tahoe. Rosa sips her coffee.

ROSA

Your wife is terrifying.

JEREMY

(watching her go)

You should see her family.

CUT TO:

**2. INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S ESTATE - KITCHEN - MORNING (7:05
AM)**

A chef's kitchen the size of a restaurant, all white
marble and morning sun. It is also, at the moment, full of
smoke.

LYRIC SOLACE BAKER (13; braids, pajamas, an apron that
says KISS THE COOK in rhinestones) stands at the
eight-burner range fanning a pan with a cutting board.

LYRIC

No, no, no, no, no.

The smoke alarm SHRIEKS.

MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (34 today, looks mid-20s; silk robe,
bare feet, the most famous face on the planet) strolls in,
reaches up without looking, and pops the battery out of

the alarm like he's done this before.

He has.

MARC-ANTHONY

Good morning, Chef.

LYRIC

Don't look!

MARC-ANTHONY

I'm not looking. I'm smelling. And what I'm smelling is either pancakes or a house fire, and honestly both are acceptable on my birthday.

LYRIC

They're birthday pancakes. There were supposed to be thirty-four of them.

MARC-ANTHONY

(peering into the pan)

How many are there?

LYRIC

(defeated)

Three. And one of them is a pancake. The other two are, like, geology.

Marc takes the spatula, plucks a charred pancake off the pan, and takes an enormous bite. He chews. He chews some more. He keeps chewing.

MARC-ANTHONY

(mouth full)

Mm. Smoky. Rustic. You can really taste the carbon.

LYRIC

(laughing)

Spit it out!

MARC-ANTHONY

I will not. A man eats what his family cooks him. That's the law.

LYRIC

That's not a law.

MARC-ANTHONY

It is in this house. I passed it at
breakfast.

He pulls her into a hug, spatula and all, and kisses the
top of her head.

LYRIC

Happy birthday, Uncle Marc.

MARC-ANTHONY

Best one yet. You know why?

LYRIC

Because you're the richest man in the
world?

MARC-ANTHONY

Because you set my kitchen on fire for
me. Nobody's ever loved me enough to
commit arson.

Lyric hops up onto the counter, which is not allowed, and
swings her feet, which is also not allowed.

LYRIC

Is my mom coming tonight?

MARC-ANTHONY

She said she'd be there.

LYRIC

She says that a lot.

MARC-ANTHONY

(gently)

And she comes a lot. Not every time.
But a lot.

LYRIC

(considering)

That's a very diplomatic answer.

MARC-ANTHONY

I'm a very diplomatic man. I've been to the White House twice and only got asked to leave once.

LYRIC

Why'd they ask you to leave?

MARC-ANTHONY

I sat in the big chair. They said nobody sits in the big chair. I said, "Well, somebody has to eventually."

Lyric laughs. Then she tilts her head, thirteen and suddenly very serious.

LYRIC

Uncle Marc. When are you going to have your own kids?

MARC-ANTHONY

(without hesitation)

Soon.

LYRIC

You always say soon.

MARC-ANTHONY

Because it's always true. I want a whole basketball team. Two teams. We'll play each other at Thanksgiving and the losers do the dishes.

LYRIC

That's like ten kids.

MARC-ANTHONY

That's a starting number.

LYRIC

Who's going to be the mom?

MARC-ANTHONY

(beat, grinning)

I'll let you know when I meet her.

LYRIC

You're thirty-four.

MARC-ANTHONY

And you're thirteen and you just set a
pan on fire. We all have our
struggles.

On the wall, a TV plays WDON-TV morning news. A graphic:
HAPPY 34TH, MARC-ANTHONY. Beneath it, a ticker: DONOHUE
COMPANY ENDS 2025 AT \$10 TRILLION...

Lyric pulls a small wrapped box from her apron pocket.

LYRIC

I have your present. But you can't
open it till tonight.

MARC-ANTHONY

Then why'd you give it to me now?

LYRIC

So you'd think about it all day.

MARC-ANTHONY

(impressed)

That's manipulation. That's elite
manipulation. I raised you right.

The back door opens. KANE MITCHELL (35; six-foot-five,
black suit, black overcoat, a face carved out of silence)
steps in, stamps the cold off his shoes, and waits.

Lyric knows the rules. She grabs a plate.

LYRIC

I'm going to go eat the good pancake
in my room.

MARC-ANTHONY

There's no good pancake.

LYRIC

(exiting)

There is now. I'm going to lie about
it.

She's gone. Marc turns to Kane. The warmth doesn't leave his face, but something behind it shifts, like a door closing somewhere deep in a big house.

MARC-ANTHONY

Morning, Kane.

KANE

Happy birthday.

MARC-ANTHONY

You say that like you're reading it off a hostage note.

KANE

(beat)

The river gave something up this morning. Under the Paces Ferry bridge.

MARC-ANTHONY

Something or someone?

KANE

Someone. Male. No name yet. APD's on it.

MARC-ANTHONY

Who at APD?

KANE

Your brother-in-law. And your sister.

Marc sets down the spatula. On the TV behind him, the anchor is still smiling about his birthday.

MARC-ANTHONY

(soft)

Find out who he is before they do.

Kane nods once and is gone. Marc stands alone in the smoky kitchen. He looks out the window, down the ridge, toward the river he can't see.

Then Lyric's voice floats down the hall.

LYRIC (O.S.)

Uncle Marc! There's a pancake stuck to
the ceiling!

And just like that, the smile is back.

MARC-ANTHONY

(calling)

Leave it! It's art now!

CUT TO:

MAIN TITLE

ACT ONE**3. INT. SUMMIT HOUSE - VICTOR'S STUDY - MORNING (8:30 AM)**

Mahogany, leather, and eighty-seven years of power. The walls hold framed Beacon front pages going back to 1939. A glass case displays four statues: an Emmy, a Grammy, an Oscar, and a Tony.

VICTOR DONOHUE (79, looks early 60s; cardigan, reading glasses, a fountain pen in a hand that has signed away continents) sits behind the enormous desk. A thick legal folder lies open in front of him.

JOAN DONOHUE (77, looks mid-50s; cream silk, pearls, a teacup she never seems to drink from) stands at the window looking down the ridge.

WINSTON ODUYA (75; the most impeccable butler in the Western Hemisphere) sets a silver coffee service on the side table.

WINSTON

The florist has arrived, madam. Four thousand white roses, as requested. They would like to know where to put the peacocks.

JOAN

There are no peacocks, Winston.

WINSTON

There are, madam. Mr. Alvin sent them. From Monaco.

Victor doesn't look up.

VICTOR

Is my son coming?

WINSTON

The card says, "Happy birthday, nephew. Wish I could be there. Here are some birds."

JOAN

(sighing)

Put them in the east garden. Somewhere they can't scream during the toasts.

WINSTON

Very good, madam.

WINSTON

And the guest list, sir. Five hundred and twelve confirmed. The Governor sends regrets. The Mayor sends a deputy.

VICTOR

The Mayor sends a deputy to everything on this ridge. She thinks it keeps her humble.

WINSTON

And the Smilley family, sir?

VICTOR

(not looking up)

The Smilleys are never invited, Winston. You know that.

WINSTON

I do, sir. I ask every year so that you can say it.

VICTOR

(dry)

Gus Smilley can watch it on my network like everybody else.

At the window, Joan's hand tightens just slightly on her teacup at the name. Victor doesn't see it. Winston does. Winston sees everything.

Winston glides out. Joan turns to Victor.

JOAN

You're signing it.

VICTOR

I signed it at five this morning. I'm reading it again because I'm old and I like the sound of my own decisions.

JOAN

Read it to me, then.

VICTOR

(reading, dry)

"The undersigned, as Chairman of The Donohue Company and holder of Class B Common Shares, hereby transfers eight hundred million Class B shares to Marc-Anthony Bullock, together with all voting rights appertaining thereto..."

JOAN

The first grandchild with a vote.

VICTOR

The first grandchild with a spine.

JOAN

Victor.

VICTOR

I said what I said.

Joan crosses to the desk. She sets down her teacup, finally.

JOAN

And tonight you'll stand on that staircase and tell the whole world he's President of the company.

VICTOR

President and Chief Operating Officer. Effective immediately.

JOAN

With Jasmine in the front row.

VICTOR

Jasmine will be where she always is.
First.

JOAN

First to be told. Last to be chosen.
You know what that does to a child.

VICTOR

(taking off his glasses)
She's fifty-five years old.

JOAN

She's your first baby. And her boy has
been waiting for this crown since he
could walk.

VICTOR

Martin has been waiting for it since
he pushed my grandson down those
stairs.

A silence. Joan looks at the study door, then back.

JOAN

We said we'd never talk about that.

VICTOR

We said we'd never talk about it to
them.

He caps the fountain pen with a small, final click.

VICTOR (CONT'D)

Twenty-one years ago I stood on that
landing on Christmas night and told
this family who its future was. I've
been proven right every day since.
Tonight I say it again, in front of
cameras, so nobody can pretend they
didn't hear me.

JOAN

Nobody's going to pretend, darling.

(beat)

They're going to plot.

VICTOR

Let them. I was plotting before their
parents were born.

Joan smiles despite herself. She leans down and kisses the
top of his head.

JOAN

I married a villain.

VICTOR

You married a king. It looks the same
in the dark.

CUT TO:

4. INT. OLSON ESTATE - BREAKFAST ROOM - MORNING (9:05 AM)

Sunlight through French doors. A table set for four,
although only three people are sitting at it.

CONGRESSWOMAN JASMINE OLSON (55, looks about 40; navy
suit, reading glasses on a chain, phone to her ear) paces.
DR. PETER OLSON (56, looks early 40s; crisp shirt,
surgeon's hands) reads the Atlanta Beacon. MALLORY OLSON
(30, looks early 20s; blowout, cashmere, an iPad full of
spreadsheets) eats yogurt with the focus of a woman
calculating quarterly revenue.

JASMINE

(into phone)

I don't want "the Chairman's
schedule," Claudette, I want to know
what my father is announcing
tonight... No. No, I am his daughter,
I don't need a press release... Then
have him call me.

She hangs up. Slams the phone face-down.

MALLORY

Grandpa's not calling you back.

JASMINE

Thank you, Mallory.

MALLORY

I'm just saying, he didn't call back at Christmas either. It's kind of a pattern. I could make you a chart.

PETER

(not looking up)

Don't make her a chart.

JASMINE

Something is happening tonight. The Beacon's running a birthday tribute on the front page. Donohue stock is up two percent in pre-market. You don't get two percent for a birthday.

PETER

Maybe the market likes cake.

JASMINE

(to Peter)

Your son isn't answering either.

The French doors open. MARTIN OLSON (34, looks late 20s; tailored navy coat, perfect haircut, the posture of a man who was born first and has never forgotten it) steps in from the cold.

He wears black leather gloves. He does not take them off.

MARTIN

Good morning, family.

JASMINE

There he is.

MARTIN

(kissing her cheek)

Madam Congresswoman.

MALLORY

You're wearing gloves inside.

MARTIN

It's thirty degrees, Mallory.

MALLORY

Inside it's seventy-two. I set the thermostat. I set everything.

MALLORY

Also, you missed Sunday dinner.

MARTIN

I had a meeting.

MALLORY

On a Sunday night?

MARTIN

Some of us work, Mal.

MALLORY

I work. I run Daddy's entire practice. I have forty-one employees and a waiting list of senators' wives.

MARTIN

You run a spreadsheet with a receptionist attached.

MALLORY

(sweetly)

And you run a TV network that's been number two in the ratings since Halloween.

JASMINE

Children.

MALLORY

He started it.

MARTIN

I'm thirty-four.

MALLORY

You started it at thirty-four. That's worse.

Martin sits. Takes a croissant with his gloved right hand. Peter lowers his newspaper just an inch.

Their eyes meet across the table.

PETER

Sleep well, son?

MARTIN

Like a baby.

PETER

Babies wake up crying at two in the morning.

A beat. Mallory looks between them. She doesn't understand it, but she feels it.

MARTIN

(smooth)

Then I slept like a man.

JASMINE

(oblivious, still pacing)

Martin, what do you hear from the Tower? You run the broadcast group. If Daddy's making an announcement, DBC has to be carrying it.

MARTIN

DBC is carrying the red carpet live at seven-thirty. Nobody told me why.

JASMINE

Nobody told you?

MARTIN

Nobody tells me anything, Mother. I'm only the eldest grandson.

JASMINE

(sitting at last, sharp)

Well, somebody should tell somebody something. I've got a state senator sniffing around my district like he smells blood, a committee hearing on media consolidation in three weeks, and my own father announcing God knows what on live television without so much as a phone call.

PETER

Jasmine, eat something.

JASMINE

I'll eat when he calls.

He smiles at her. It doesn't touch his eyes.

MARTIN (CONT'D)

Don't worry. Whatever Grandfather says tonight, the family will be there to hear it.

(beat)

And the family has a long memory.

He bites into the croissant. Peter goes back to his newspaper, but he isn't reading anymore.

CUT TO:

5. INT. APD HEADQUARTERS - CHIEF'S OFFICE - DAY (10:15 AM)

Downtown Atlanta through floor-to-ceiling windows. Framed on the wall: a photo of former Chief WALTER JACKSON pinning a badge on a young Elxa.

Elxa sits behind the desk. Jeremy and Rosa stand across from her with a thin folder.

ROSA

The M.E. puts time of death between ten last night and one this morning. Manual strangulation. Hyoid's broken. And there's bruising on his ribs, like somebody knelt on him.

ELXA

A fight.

JEREMY

A lopsided one. He's got defensive wounds, but whoever did it was stronger. A lot stronger.

ELXA

Prints?

ROSA

Running them. The river wasn't kind to his fingers.

JEREMY

One more thing. His watch. It stopped at eleven-forty-one.

ELXA

The water?

JEREMY

The water. So he went in at eleven-forty-one, or close to it.

Elxa leans back. She looks at the photo of her father-in-law on the wall.

ELXA

The coat was expensive?

ROSA

Italian. Custom. Whoever this guy was, somebody was paying him well.

ELXA

Then somebody's going to miss him. When they do, I want to know about it before the news does.

JEREMY
We'll do this right.

ELXA
Do it fast.

JEREMY
(evenly)
Right is fast. Wrong just feels fast
until the appeal.

Rosa looks at the floor. Elxa looks at her husband.

Elxa's desk phone buzzes. She hits the speaker.

ASSISTANT (V.O.)
Chief, the Mayor's office on line two.
They heard about the river.

ELXA
Tell the Mayor's office I'll call them
when I have something worth hearing.

ASSISTANT (V.O.)
They said you'd say that.

ELXA
Then tell them they're very
perceptive.

She clicks off. Rosa bites back a smile.

ELXA
Detective Delgado, would you give us
the room?

ROSA
(already moving)
Gladly.

She exits. The door closes. Elxa stands, comes around the
desk.

ELXA
Don't do that in front of my people.

JEREMY

Do what? Agree with the law?

ELXA

Talk to me like I'm your partner
instead of your boss.

JEREMY

You're my wife.

ELXA

Not in this building.

A beat. Jeremy softens.

JEREMY

Okay. Chief. With respect. You looked
up that ridge this morning like you
were afraid of what's up there.

ELXA

I wasn't afraid.

JEREMY

Then what was it?

Elxa goes to the window. The city shines under a hard
winter sun.

ELXA

I grew up on that ridge. Everything
that happens in this city washes down
from it eventually. Money, power,
favours. Bodies, sometimes.

(beat)

I just want to be the one standing at
the bottom when it lands.

JEREMY

That's not a crime, Elxa.

ELXA

Not yet.

She turns back to him. Her face softens. She straightens
his tie, which is already straight.

ELXA (CONT'D)

Eight o'clock. The tux. And try to
look like you like my family.

JEREMY

I like your family.

ELXA

Nobody likes my family, Jeremy.
They're just too scared to say so.

CUT TO:

**6. EXT. SMILLEY ESTATE - TUXEDO PARK - ESTHER'S TERRACE -
DAY (11:00 AM)**

A stone terrace high above manicured lawns. Beyond the
trees, across the ridge, the white columns of Summit House
catch the sun.

ESTHER SMILLEY (33, looks early 20s; the most beautiful
woman in the world, in a camel coat and sunglasses,
holding a coffee she isn't drinking) stares at it.

HARMONY DIVINE (33, looks mid-20s; thrifted leather
jacket, a camera bag, an attitude older than her car)
climbs the terrace steps two at a time.

HARMONY

You know you can see it better from
the roof.

ESTHER

I'm not looking at anything.

HARMONY

You're looking at Summit House like it
owes you money.

ESTHER

It does. The Donohues owe everybody
money. They just charge it back as
licensing fees.

Harmony flops into a chaise. Steals Esther's coffee.
Drinks it.

HARMONY

So you're not coming tonight.

ESTHER

I'm not invited tonight.

HARMONY

Nobody from Tuxedo Park is invited tonight. That's never stopped you before.

ESTHER

I've never once set foot in that house.

HARMONY

Exactly. Fourteen years, Esther. Every Crest party, every gala, every christening.

(pointed)

Including my daughter's.

ESTHER

I sent a gift.

HARMONY

You sent a Bentley stroller.

ESTHER

It was a very nice stroller.

HARMONY

Lyric was six months old, not a Kardashian.

Esther finally laughs. It's brief. She turns back to the view.

HARMONY

Besides. I'm not in the mood to be around people who own things.

ESTHER

You're on my terrace.

HARMONY

You don't count. You're my sister.
Your stuff is basically my stuff that
I'm too proud to use.

ESTHER

How did the pitch go?

HARMONY

(beat)

Which one?

ESTHER

The one on Friday. The streamer.

HARMONY

They said, and I'm quoting, "We love
the voice. We just don't know who it's
for."

ESTHER

It's for everybody.

HARMONY

That's what I said. They said
"everybody" isn't a demographic.

ESTHER

That's rejection number...

HARMONY

Forty. A nice round number. I'm going
to frame it.

ESTHER

Let me make one phone call.

HARMONY

(instantly)

No.

ESTHER

Harmony.

HARMONY

The day I let a Smilley buy my movie
is the day it stops being my movie. We
talked about this.

ESTHER

We talked about it when we were
nineteen.

HARMONY

And I'm still right.

HARMONY (CONT'D)

Lyric wants me there. Marc throws the
party every year at his grandparents'
and invites every kid on the ridge.
She'll be up past midnight on sugar
and camera flashes.

ESTHER

And you'll go and stand in a corner
and hate everybody.

HARMONY

I'll stand in a corner and hate
everybody in a very good dress.
There's a difference.

ESTHER

Will Amond be there?

HARMONY

(too fast)

I don't know Amond's schedule.

ESTHER

You memorized Amond's schedule in the
eleventh grade.

HARMONY

We're on a break.

ESTHER

You're always on a break.

HARMONY

Some breaks are longer than others.

A pause. Harmony studies her best friend.

HARMONY (CONT'D)

Come with me.

ESTHER

No.

HARMONY

One hour. One drink. You stand next to me and roll your eyes at rich people. You're good at that.

ESTHER

(beat)

I'd rather be buried in the east garden.

HARMONY

The Donohues probably have a section for that.

Esther smiles, but her grip tightens on the stone railing. Harmony notices. Harmony notices everything.

HARMONY (CONT'D)

(gently)

What is it about him?

ESTHER

About who?

HARMONY

Marc-Anthony Bullock. Every time somebody says his name you look like you swallowed a bee.

ESTHER

(cool again)

He's a Donohue. I'm a Smilley. We're allergic to each other. It's genetic.

She says the last word a half-second too carefully. Harmony hears it. She lets it go.

For now.

HARMONY

Tell the girls I said hi. And tell
them Lyric's saving them cake.

ESTHER

They're not going anywhere near that
house.

HARMONY

It's cake, Esther.

ESTHER

(firm)

Nowhere near it.

Harmony shrugs, sets down the stolen coffee, and heads
back down the steps. Esther doesn't turn around. She keeps
staring across the ridge at the white columns glittering
in the sun.

CUT TO:

ACT TWO**7. INT. DONOHUE TOWER - NATASHA'S OFFICE - DAY (12:30 PM)**

The top floor of the tallest building in the South. All Atlanta is laid out below like a toy set. A wall of Natasha's awards: an Emmy, a Grammy, a Tony. One empty shelf.

NATASHA BULLOCK (54, looks late 30s; ivory suit, stilettos, the CEO of the most valuable company on Earth) signs contracts at a glass desk without reading them. She's already read them.

ROBERT BULLOCK (56, looks early 40s; charcoal three-piece, gold cufflinks, a smile that has made juries cry) lounges on her sofa eating almonds.

ROBERT

Your father called me this morning.

NATASHA

My father doesn't call you.

ROBERT

That's why I picked up. I assumed somebody died.

NATASHA

What did he want?

ROBERT

He wanted to know if I'd drafted a share transfer before. I said, "Victor, I've drafted things that would make the Pope blush." He hung up.

NATASHA

He's giving Marc Class B.

ROBERT

(sitting up)

Voting shares.

NATASHA

Eight hundred million of them. And the President's chair.

Robert whistles low.

ROBERT

Tonight?

NATASHA

Tonight. On the staircase. In front of God, DBC, and my sister.

ROBERT

Jasmine's going to lose her mind.

NATASHA

Jasmine lost her mind in 1971, the day I was born. She's been renting it back from me ever since.

Robert laughs. He crosses to the window beside her.

ROBERT

You ready for this?

NATASHA

I've been ready since the day he was born. I told you in the delivery room.

ROBERT

You told me you were going to kill me in the delivery room.

NATASHA

That too. I contain multitudes.

ROBERT

(serious now)

Tasha. He's a sweet boy.

NATASHA

He's a brilliant man.

ROBERT

He's both. That's what worries me. He cries at dog food commercials.

NATASHA

So did you, the night Elxa was born.

ROBERT

That was allergies.

NATASHA

In August?

ROBERT

It was a very allergic August.

She takes his hand. Just for a moment, the most powerful couple in Atlanta are two kids from 1989 again.

NATASHA

They underestimate sweet, Robert. They always have. Right up until sweet eats them alive.

ROBERT

(beat)

Is that how you got me?

NATASHA

No, baby. I got you with a dare and a Honda Civic.

She kisses him and goes back to her contracts. Robert looks down at the city, still smiling, but his lawyer's eyes are already calculating.

ROBERT

(nodding at the empty shelf
on her award wall)

Seventeen days.

NATASHA

Don't.

ROBERT

The Academy announces nominations in seventeen days, and you haven't said the word "Oscar" once since Christmas.

NATASHA

Because every time I say it out loud,
it runs away.

ROBERT

Three nominations, no statue. Baby,
that's not running away. That's
playing hard to get.

NATASHA

(beat)

If I get the call on the
twenty-second, you'll be there?

ROBERT

Tasha, I'll be there if I have to get
a client acquitted by lunch to do it.

NATASHA

You'd do that for me?

ROBERT

I'd do that for a sandwich. For you
I'd get two acquitted.

ROBERT

Martin's going to be at that party.

NATASHA

Martin's family.

ROBERT

So was Cain.

CUT TO:

8. INT. BELMONT CREST COUNTRY CLUB - THE VAULT - DAY (1:30 PM)

A private dining room with no windows, oak paneling, and a single round table where half of Atlanta's biggest deals have been made. MALIK FREEMAN (30; head bartender, bow tie, a face that has heard everything and repeated nothing) pours three glasses of champagne.

At the table: Marc-Anthony in a cashmere sweater; AMOND BAKER (33, looks mid-20s; sharp suit, sharper jaw, a man in a hurry to become somebody); and ATTORNEY GENERAL ARIANNA CUMMINGS (33, looks mid-20s; red blazer, briefcase at her feet, a woman who has never once been late to anything).

The Belmont Crest Three.

AMOND

To the birthday boy. Thirty-four years old and still hasn't paid for a single lunch.

MARC-ANTHONY

I'm saving up.

ARIANNA

You're worth nine hundred and ninety billion dollars.

MARC-ANTHONY

And I didn't get there by buying you two sandwiches.

They drink. Malik discreetly steps out. The door closes. Nobody else in the world can hear them now.

ARIANNA

How's Broadway?

MARC-ANTHONY

Sebastian Crowe called me at four in the morning London time to tell me my grandfather "sang the rafters down" in 1972 and he needs me to "sing the basement up."

AMOND

What does that even mean?

MARC-ANTHONY

I don't know. I think it's British for "try harder." Rehearsals start next month. If I don't get that Tony this time, I'm going to move to London and become a villain in a period drama.

AMOND

You'd never leave Atlanta.

MARC-ANTHONY

I'd leave Atlanta. I'd be so gone. I'd send postcards. "Dear Atlanta, London is lovely, the tea is weak, I miss lemon pepper wings, please send help."

ARIANNA

You'd be a terrible villain.

MARC-ANTHONY

I'd be an incredible villain. I'd wear a cape. I'd twirl a mustache I grew specifically for the role. I'd have a monocle and a very sad backstory about a horse.

AMOND

Seriously, man. How does it feel? Thirty-four.

MARC-ANTHONY

It's weird. My knees make noises now. I stood up out of the car this morning and it sounded like somebody opening a bag of chips.

ARIANNA

That's arthritis.

MARC-ANTHONY

It's rhythm. My body's making music now. I'm going to sample it.

AMOND

Your body's going to be making a lot of noise tonight. You know what your grandfather's doing, right?

MARC-ANTHONY

Throwing me a party with four thousand roses and screaming birds.

AMOND

Birds?

MARC-ANTHONY

Uncle Alvin sent peacocks from Monaco. Instead of coming. Which is the most Uncle Alvin thing that's ever happened.

ARIANNA

(quietly)

Marc. The whole city's saying it. Stock's up. DBC's carrying the carpet live. Victor's naming you tonight.

MARC-ANTHONY

Naming me what? Grandson of the Year? I won that in '04. Martin still hasn't recovered.

AMOND

(not laughing)

He hasn't. You know he hasn't.

A beat. The joke leaves Marc's face.

MARC-ANTHONY

I know.

ARIANNA

Just watch your back up there.

MARC-ANTHONY

That's what I have you two for. Front and back. And a sister who carries a gun. I'm very well covered.

Arianna hesitates, like she wants to say something else.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)

What?

ARIANNA

Nothing. Friday. I have news.

AMOND

Good news or AG news?

ARIANNA

Is there a difference?

MARC-ANTHONY

You're pregnant.

ARIANNA

I'm not pregnant.

MARC-ANTHONY

You're pregnant with twins and the father is the Governor.

ARIANNA

(laughing despite herself)

Oh my God. Friday.

She gathers her briefcase and stands.

ARIANNA (CONT'D)

Happy birthday, you idiot.

She kisses Marc's cheek, squeezes Amond's shoulder, and goes. The door closes behind her.

Now it's just the two of them. The easy energy in the room changes, the way it does between two men who share a secret.

MARC-ANTHONY

(low)

Who's not answering?

AMOND

(low)

T-Bone missed check-in last night. And this morning. His phone's dead. His girl says he left the house at nine and never came back.

MARC-ANTHONY

(beat)

The river.

AMOND

Could be anybody in that river.

MARC-ANTHONY

It's never anybody, Mon. It's always somebody.

He stares into his champagne.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)

Find him. If he's alive, I want him in front of me tonight. If he's not, I want to know who made him not.

AMOND

And if it was one of ours?

MARC-ANTHONY

Then it's worse.

Amond nods. He finishes his drink.

AMOND

Happy birthday, brother.

MARC-ANTHONY

(the smile returning, a little tired)

Best one yet.

CUT TO:

**9. INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S ESTATE - LYRIC'S ROOM - AFTERNOON
(3:45 PM)**

A thirteen-year-old's dream: vanity mirror with lights, a wall of film posters (all of them Marc's), a script on the bed with sticky notes. Harmony sits cross-legged on the floor, braiding Lyric's hair while Lyric runs lines out loud.

LYRIC

(reading, dramatic)

"You don't get to tell me who I am.
I've been deciding that since before
you knew my name."

HARMONY

Good. Say it again, but slower. Like
you've been waiting a long time to say
it.

LYRIC

(slower)

"You don't get to tell me who I am..."

She stops. Looks at her mother in the mirror.

LYRIC (CONT'D)

That was good direction.

HARMONY

I'm a good director.

LYRIC

I know. Uncle Marc says so too.

HARMONY

(a little sharp)

Does he.

LYRIC

He says you're the best one in Atlanta
and nobody knows it yet.

Harmony's hands pause in Lyric's hair. Then they keep going.

HARMONY

That's nice of him.

LYRIC

He's nice about everybody.

HARMONY

I know, baby. That's his whole thing.

LYRIC

Are you and Daddy talking?

HARMONY

We're on a break.

LYRIC

You were on a break at Thanksgiving.

HARMONY

It's a long break.

LYRIC

(carefully)

He's going to be there tonight. He got a new suit. He showed me a picture. He asked me if you'd like it.

HARMONY

(beat)

What did you tell him?

LYRIC

I told him you'd say you didn't like it and then look at him all night.

Harmony laughs, caught. She ties off the braid.

HARMONY

When did you get so smart?

LYRIC

I live with a genius. It's contagious.

Harmony's smile goes thin. She glances around the room: the enormous closet, the posters, the view of the ridge. None of it is hers. None of it came from her.

HARMONY

Are Emma and Victoria coming tonight?

LYRIC

(sighing)

Their mom won't let them. Their mom never lets them come to anything on the ridge.

HARMONY

(careful)

I know, baby.

LYRIC

It's weird, right? Uncle Marc's the nicest person in Atlanta and she acts like he's radioactive.

HARMONY

(a beat too long)

Some people have their reasons.

LYRIC

What reasons?

HARMONY

Grown-up reasons.

LYRIC

That's what grown-ups say when the reason is embarrassing.

Harmony laughs, but she doesn't answer.

HARMONY

You like it here.

LYRIC

(gently)

Mama. You ask me that every time.

HARMONY

And you always say yes.

LYRIC

Because it's always yes.

(beat)
But I like it when you come.

Harmony kisses the top of her head. She reaches for her camera bag, pulls out a worn laptop, and slides it underneath, out of sight.

HARMONY
Go get dressed. And don't let your uncle give you coffee.

LYRIC
He gives me decaf and tells me it's espresso.

HARMONY
That man lies to children.

LYRIC
(skipping off)
Only the good lies!

CUT TO:

10. INT. OLSON ESTATE - MARTIN'S DRESSING ROOM - EARLY EVENING (5:00 PM)

A long mirror. A tuxedo on a valet stand. Martin, alone, in his dress shirt.

He takes off the black leather gloves, finger by finger.

His right hand is wrapped in fresh white gauze. He peels it back. Eight neat black stitches run across the split knuckles.

He flexes the hand. It hurts. He does it again anyway.

He looks at himself in the mirror and begins, quietly, to practice.

MARTIN
(to the mirror)
Grandfather. Congratulations, Marc.
What a wonderful night for the family.

He tilts his head. Tries again, warmer.

MARTIN (CONT'D)

What a wonderful, wonderful night.

The door opens. Jasmine enters in an evening gown, earrings in her hand. She stops.

JASMINE

What happened to your hand?

MARTIN

(rewrapping it, easy)

Racquetball.

JASMINE

You don't play racquetball.

MARTIN

And now you know why.

She crosses to him. Takes his wrapped hand in both of hers, like she did when he was a boy.

JASMINE

Your grandfather is going to do something tonight.

MARTIN

I know.

JASMINE

Something that hurts.

MARTIN

I know, Mother.

JASMINE

(fierce, quiet)

You were born first. You were born to me, first. Whatever he says on those stairs, that doesn't change.

Martin looks at her. For a moment there's something real in his face, a boy who wanted to be chosen.

Then it's gone.

MARTIN

Let him have his night.

JASMINE

And tomorrow?

MARTIN

(pulling on the black
gloves)

Tomorrow we'll do something.

ACT THREE**11. EXT. SUMMIT HOUSE - MOTOR COURT - NIGHT (7:45 PM)**

The house blazes with light. The great white columns glow gold. A red carpet runs from the fountain to the front doors between velvet ropes, and a wall of PHOTOGRAPHERS and DBC cameras roars every time a car door opens.

A Rolls-Royce pulls up. GRACE BULLOCK (31, looks early 20s; emerald gown, diamonds, the face half the directors in Hollywood fight over) steps out and owns the flashbulbs.

PHOTOGRAPHERS

Grace! Grace! Over here! Who are you wearing? Grace!

GRACE

(dazzling)

Myself, mostly!

Behind her, a black Maybach. Mallory steps out in silver, flanked by Peter and Jasmine. Jasmine smiles for the cameras like she's being paid to. Martin exits last, gloved, and gives the lenses exactly one perfect wave.

Grace sidles up to Mallory.

GRACE (CONT'D)

(under her breath)

Your mother looks like she's here to accept a verdict.

MALLORY

(under her breath)

She's here to appeal one.

GRACE

And your brother's wearing gloves.

MALLORY

He says it's racquetball.

GRACE

Martin doesn't play racquetball.

MALLORY

That's what I said!

A Tahoe screeches in at the curb, three minutes late. Elxa steps out in a black gown and a borrowed diamond necklace, badge clipped discreetly at her hip. Jeremy climbs out behind her in a tux, still on his phone.

JEREMY

(into phone)

Text me the second prints come back.
Anything. Even a partial.

ELXA

Jeremy.

JEREMY

(hanging up)

Tux. Smile. Family. I know.

A town car. Arianna steps out in deep red, and the political press surges forward.

POLITICAL REPORTER

Madam Attorney General! Madam Attorney General, any truth to the rumors about 2028?

ARIANNA

(without breaking stride)

It's a birthday party, Kevin. The only thing I'm running for is the bar.

The press laughs. Behind her, Amond steps out of a silver Aston Martin in his new suit and scans the crowd for one face. He doesn't find it yet.

A final car. The crowd goes feral. Marc-Anthony steps out of a vintage 1972 Rolls in a midnight-blue tuxedo with Lyric on his arm, her new braids glittering. He waves, bows, blows kisses, and spins Lyric under his arm like they're at a wedding.

PHOTOGRAPHERS

Marc! Marc-Anthony! Happy birthday!
How does it feel to be thirty-four?

MARC-ANTHONY

(to the cameras)
Like thirty-three, but louder!

PHOTOGRAPHER

Any birthday wishes?

MARC-ANTHONY

World peace, clean water, and a
pancake that doesn't fight back!

Lyric doubles over laughing. The press loves it. Grace catches her brother's eye across the carpet. He winks.

GRACE

(to Mallory, fond)
My brother. The only man who could
make a birthday party feel like a
campaign rally.

CUT TO:

12. INT. SUMMIT HOUSE - GRAND FOYER - NIGHT (8:02 PM)

Crystal. Marble. Old money that is ours. A string quartet plays beneath the sweeping double staircase. Four thousand white roses climb the banisters. Five hundred GUESTS in black tie hold champagne and wait.

Grace and Mallory stand near the foot of the stairs.

GRACE

(low, to Mallory)
He only comes down those stairs when
he's about to change somebody's life.

MALLORY

Then let's hope it's not ours.

The music stops. Every eye goes to the top of the stairs.

VICTOR DONOHUE appears on the landing in a white dinner jacket, Joan on his arm in silver. The room erupts in applause. Victor raises one hand. The applause stops so fast it's a little frightening.

VICTOR

Good evening.

(beat)

Thirty-four years ago tonight, my daughter Natasha called me from Crawford Long Hospital and said, "Daddy, he's here, and he's loud."

Laughter. Natasha, near the front with Robert, raises her glass.

VICTOR (CONT'D)

She wasn't wrong. He hasn't been quiet a day since. And on behalf of my wife, and on behalf of this family, I want to thank you all for coming out on a Monday night in January to help us celebrate him.

(beat)

Eat. Drink. Dance. At ten o'clock I'll have a few words.

(dry)

I'm eighty in May. I'm allowed to make you wait.

Big laughter. The quartet starts up again. Victor and Joan descend into the crowd.

Near the fireplace, Jasmine turns to Peter, her smile frozen in place.

JASMINE

"A few words."

PETER

Jasmine.

JASMINE

At ten o'clock. So the East Coast
feeds pick it up live.

PETER

Maybe he wants to go to bed early.

JASMINE

Daddy has never done anything early in
his life except win.

CUT TO:

13. INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - ESTHER'S BEDROOM - NIGHT (8:05 PM)

Dark. Only the glow of a laptop on the bed. Esther sits in the middle of it in silk pajamas, knees drawn to her chest, watching a PULSE livestream: the Summit House red carpet, replaying on a loop.

On screen, Marc-Anthony spins Lyric under his arm and laughs.

Esther doesn't blink.

From down the hall comes MUSIC through a closed door, a pop song and two girls singing along, badly and loudly. Esther glances toward the sound. Something tender and terrified crosses her face.

She looks back at the screen. Marc, frozen mid-laugh in the paused frame.

She reaches out and touches the screen. Right on his face. Then she pulls her hand back like it burned her.

ESTHER

(whisper)

Happy birthday.

She slams the laptop shut. The room goes black.

CUT TO:

14. INT. SUMMIT HOUSE - BALLROOM - NIGHT (8:20 PM)

Gold and glass. A jazz band on a raised stage. Guests fill the dance floor. At the center of it all, Marc-Anthony works the room like a heavyweight working a crowd: hugging the valet's mother, taking a selfie with a senator, doing a terrible impression of his own grandfather for a gaggle of delighted guests.

MARC-ANTHONY

(as Victor, gravel-voiced)

"I don't make threats, son. I make acquisitions."

GUESTS

(howling)

He spots Elxa arriving at the edge of the dance floor, still pinning an earring, and breaks away to scoop her into a hug that lifts her off her feet.

MARC-ANTHONY

The Chief! Everybody, the Chief of Police! Nobody jaywalk!

ELXA

Put me down, you lunatic.

MARC-ANTHONY

(setting her down)

You're late.

ELXA

Somebody died.

MARC-ANTHONY

(instantly gentle)

I heard. Under the bridge.

ELXA

(beat)

Where'd you hear that?

MARC-ANTHONY

WDON. Channel 5. Your husband's handsome face on the noon news telling everybody "no comment" like a very sexy brick wall.

ELXA

(studying him)

Hm.

MARC-ANTHONY

What's "hm"?

ELXA

Your guy. Kane. He was at the scene perimeter this morning. Parked across the road for twenty minutes.

A flicker, so brief only a sister would see it. Then Marc shrugs.

MARC-ANTHONY

Kane drives the river road every morning. He says it's meditative. I think he just likes staring at water. He's a very deep man. Like, emotionally. Also, possibly, a mermaid.

ELXA

(not laughing)

Marc.

MARC-ANTHONY

Elxa. It's my birthday. Arrest me tomorrow.

She holds his gaze a moment more. Then she lets it go and fixes his bow tie, the way she's done since he was five.

ELXA

Happy birthday, baby brother.

MARC-ANTHONY

Best one yet.

She goes to find Jeremy. Marc watches her go, and for just a second, the smile isn't there.

Behind him, Joan clears her throat. Marc turns. Doesn't miss a beat.

MARC-ANTHONY

(as himself, instantly)

And that concludes my tribute to the greatest man who ever lived.

JOAN

Nice save.

MARC-ANTHONY

I've been practicing that save since the third grade.

JOAN

(taking his arm)

Walk with me.

They stroll along the edge of the dance floor. She steers him past a knot of guests toward the tall windows overlooking the dark ridge.

JOAN (CONT'D)

Your grandfather's going to hand you something heavy tonight.

MARC-ANTHONY

Grandma, if it's another painting of himself, I'm running out of walls.

JOAN

It isn't a painting.

She stops. Looks at him properly.

JOAN (CONT'D)

When he's done talking, half this room will want to hug you and the other half will want to bury you. Most of them will do both.

MARC-ANTHONY

(gently)

I know who's who.

JOAN

You think you do. That's what worries me. You're the best of us, baby. You see the good in everybody.

MARC-ANTHONY

Not everybody.

Something in the way he says it makes Joan look at him more carefully.

JOAN

No. Not everybody.

Near the dessert table, Robert corners Jeremy, who is trying to eat a single shrimp without being noticed.

ROBERT

Detective.

JEREMY

Counselor.

ROBERT

Heard you pulled a floater out of the Chattahoochee this morning.

JEREMY

I can't talk about an open investigation, sir.

ROBERT

I'm not asking you to talk. I'm asking you to listen.

(beat)

Whoever you arrest for it, there's a good chance they'll call me.

JEREMY

There's a good chance they'll be guilty.

ROBERT
(delighted)
Son, that's never once stopped me.

He pats Jeremy on the shoulder like a proud father-in-law and saunters off. Jeremy stares after him and puts the shrimp down.

At a cocktail table nearby, Grace and Mallory hold identical champagne flutes and survey the room like two queens surveying a battlefield.

MALLORY
Senator Whitcomb is looking at you.

GRACE
Senator Whitcomb is sixty-eight and married.

MALLORY
He's looking at you like he's neither.

GRACE
Everyone's looking at somebody tonight. My brother's looking at the door every five minutes.

MALLORY
For who?

GRACE
(sipping)
That's what I'd like to know.

Across the room, Jasmine and Natasha find each other at the bar. Two sisters in couture, fifty-five and fifty-four, smiling for any cameras that might be watching.

NATASHA
You look beautiful.

JASMINE
You look nervous.

NATASHA
I'm never nervous.

JASMINE

You're holding your glass by the bowl.
You always hold it by the bowl when
you're nervous. You did it at your
wedding.

NATASHA

I was pregnant at my wedding. I was
holding it by the bowl to keep from
drinking it.

JASMINE

(tight smile)

You were always good at getting what
you wanted before anybody else was
allowed to want it.

NATASHA

Say what you mean, Jazz.

JASMINE

I mean you know what's coming at ten
o'clock.

NATASHA

(beat)

I know what's coming at ten o'clock.

JASMINE

And you didn't call me.

NATASHA

Daddy didn't call you. I'm not his
secretary.

JASMINE

No. You're his favorite.

She sets her glass down on the bar, precise as a gavel,
and walks away. Natasha watches her go and, very
carefully, moves her own fingers to the stem of her glass.

ACT FOUR**15. INT. SUMMIT HOUSE - LIBRARY - NIGHT (8:45 PM)**

Floor-to-ceiling books, rolling ladders, a fire. Muffled music leaks through the doors. Jeremy stands by the fireplace, texting. Elxa enters with two plates of food.

ELXA

You're hiding.

JEREMY

I'm working.

ELXA

In the library. Of my grandparents' house. At my brother's birthday.

JEREMY

There's good light.

She hands him a plate. He takes it without looking at it.

JEREMY (CONT'D)

Prints are still running. The river messed them up. We might need dental.

ELXA

Tomorrow.

JEREMY

Somebody's mother is waiting to hear her son is dead.

Elxa sits on the arm of a leather chair. She looks around the room, at the fire, the books, the portraits of four generations of Donohues.

ELXA

When I was a little girl, every Christmas Eve Granddaddy read to us in here. All of us on the rug. Me, Marc, Grace, Martin, Mallory. Martin always sat closest.

JEREMY

Sounds nice.

ELXA

It was.

(beat)

I want that. I want our kids on that rug someday.

Jeremy's thumb stops on his phone. Just for a second.

JEREMY

Elxa.

ELXA

I'm not asking for tonight. I'm just saying it out loud so it's in the room.

JEREMY

(setting down the plate)

Can we do this after the case?

ELXA

There's always a case.

JEREMY

Then after this one.

She looks at him a long time. He can't hold her gaze. He looks at the fire instead.

ELXA

You always say after.

JEREMY

Because after is when I'll know what I'm saying.

ELXA

What does that mean?

JEREMY

(quiet)

It means I love you. And it means not tonight.

ELXA
(soft)
Okay.

The library door opens. Kane Mitchell steps in, scans the room, sees them, and nods politely.

KANE
Chief. Detective. Excuse me. Looking
for Mr. Bullock.

ELXA
Which one?

KANE
(beat)
The birthday one.

ELXA
Try the dance floor. Or the dessert
table. Or wherever the loudest laugh
is.

KANE
Thank you, Chief.

He goes. Elxa watches the door close behind him. A cop's instinct. She doesn't know why he bothers her. He just does.

JEREMY
Who's that?

ELXA
Kane. Marc's head of security.

JEREMY
Big guy.

ELXA
(still watching the door)
Quiet guy.

CUT TO:

16. EXT. SUMMIT HOUSE - TERRACE - NIGHT (9:00 PM)

Cold stars over the ridge. Heat lamps glow along a stone balustrade. Harmony stands alone at the far end with a glass of wine in a black dress that stops conversations.

Footsteps. Amond appears in a new suit, midnight gray, perfect.

AMOND

You look...

HARMONY

Don't.

AMOND

I was going to say "cold."

HARMONY

You were going to say "beautiful."

AMOND

I was going to say "beautiful" and then you said "don't," so I pivoted to "cold."

HARMONY

Smooth.

AMOND

I'm a businessman. I adapt.

She almost smiles. Catches herself.

HARMONY

Nice suit.

AMOND

Lyric said you'd hate it.

HARMONY

Lyric has a big mouth.

AMOND

She gets that from you.

HARMONY

She gets everything from me. That's the problem.

He moves closer. She doesn't move away.

AMOND

Harm. Come home.

HARMONY

I don't have a home, Amond. I have an apartment in Adamsville and a daughter who lives in a castle.

AMOND

That's not what I meant.

HARMONY

I know what you meant.

(beat)

And I know what happens. We're good for a month. You buy me something too expensive. I feel like a charity case. I say something cruel. You take it. And then you look at me like that.

AMOND

Like what?

HARMONY

Like you'd take it forever.

AMOND

(simply)

I would.

That lands. She looks away, across the dark ridge toward the lights of Tuxedo Park.

HARMONY

That's the problem with you.

AMOND

That I love you?

HARMONY

That you don't know when to stop.

She hands him her wine glass and walks back inside. Amond stands alone under the heat lamps, holding her glass.

He takes a sip from the side her lipstick marked.

CUT TO:

Amond steps back inside to the ballroom bar, still holding Harmony's glass. Martin is there, alone, nursing a scotch in his gloved hand.

MARTIN

Amond Baker.

AMOND

Martin.

MARTIN

You look like a man who just lost an argument with a woman.

AMOND

You look like a man who wears gloves indoors.

MARTIN

(amused)

Touché.

(beat)

Can I ask you something, as one second son to another?

AMOND

I'm an only child.

MARTIN

I didn't mean in your family.

Amond goes still. Martin sips his scotch.

MARTIN (CONT'D)

Twenty-five years at his side. The best friend. The brother. The right hand. And tonight my grandfather is going to hand him an empire in front of five hundred people.

(beat)

Where are you going to be standing when that happens, Amond? Front row? Or the back of the room, holding a woman's empty glass?

AMOND

(cold)

Right where I always stand.

MARTIN

That's what I was afraid of. For your sake.

He sets a business card on the bar. Donohue Broadcasting Group. His private number handwritten on the back.

MARTIN (CONT'D)

When you get tired of standing, call me.

He leaves the card and walks away. Amond looks at it for a long moment.

He doesn't pick it up.

Then, as the band starts a new song, he does.

17. INT. SUMMIT HOUSE - BALLROOM - NIGHT (9:15 PM)

The band finishes a song. Lyric climbs onto the stage and takes the microphone from the bandleader, standing on her tiptoes to reach it.

LYRIC

Um. Hi. Excuse me. Hi.

The room turns. Awws and laughter. Marc, near the bar with Grace, looks up, surprised.

LYRIC (CONT'D)

My name is Lyric Solace Baker and I'm thirteen and I'm an actress, and this is my first time talking in front of this many people without a script.

Laughter.

LYRIC (CONT'D)

My Uncle Marc isn't really my uncle. He's my godfather. And when I was eight, I had to come live with him, and I was really scared, because I didn't know if he'd want me.

The room goes quiet. At the back, Harmony has stepped in from the terrace. She freezes. So does Amond, behind her.

LYRIC (CONT'D)

The first night, I couldn't sleep. And he came and sat on the floor outside my door. He didn't come in. He just sat there. And he told me stories through the door until I fell asleep. He did it every night for a month.

(beat)

I found out later he had to be on set at five in the morning. He never told me.

Grace puts a hand on Marc's back. His jaw is tight. His eyes are shining.

LYRIC (CONT'D)

So anyway. I made him pancakes this morning and they were really, really bad. And he ate one anyway. Because he says a man eats what his family cooks him.

(beat)

So. Happy birthday to the best man I know. You're my family.

She sets the microphone down. The room explodes into applause. Marc crosses the dance floor, lifts her off the stage in a hug, and spins her around. People are crying. Joan is crying. Even Victor, at the edge of the room, dabs at one eye with a pocket square.

At the back of the room, Harmony presses her fingers hard against her mouth. Amond, behind her, doesn't say a word. He just puts a hand on her shoulder.

She doesn't shake it off.

Near the bar, Martin applauds too, slowly, in black leather gloves.

Peter, beside him, looks down at those gloves. Then up at his son's face.

PETER

(quiet)

You should take those off.

MARTIN

(still smiling, still
clapping)

You should mind your business.

CUT TO:

18. INT. SUMMIT HOUSE - SERVICE CORRIDOR - NIGHT (9:30 PM)

A narrow back passage behind the kitchen. Waiters rush past with trays. Marc stands against the wall, still wiping his eyes with the heel of his hand, when Kane appears beside him.

MARC-ANTHONY

Don't say anything about the crying.

KANE

I wasn't going to.

MARC-ANTHONY

I wasn't crying. I had a pancake in my eye. It's been in there since seven a.m.

KANE

(quiet)

The man in the river. APD's got his time of death around eleven-forty last night. Strangled. Bare hands. Somebody knelt on him.

Marc's face goes still.

MARC-ANTHONY

Any name?

KANE

Not yet. Amond still can't find T-Bone.

A waiter squeezes past. They wait until he's gone.

MARC-ANTHONY

Tell Zeke. Tonight. I want to know everyone who walked across that bridge last night. Everyone who drove over it. Every camera between here and the river.

KANE

And if it's him?

MARC-ANTHONY

(beat)

Then somebody took one of ours on my birthday.

He straightens his bow tie. He checks his reflection in the dark window of a service door. The tears are gone. His eyes are clear and very, very calm.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)

And I'm going to want to meet them.

He pushes back through the door into the light and noise of the party. By the time he's on the other side he's laughing again.

Kane watches him go. Then he takes out his phone and makes a call.

KANE
(into phone)
It's me. Wake up Zeke.

ACT FIVE**19. INT. SUMMIT HOUSE - GRAND FOYER - NIGHT (10:00 PM)**

Just before ten. A quiet alcove off the foyer behind a curtain of white roses. Natasha adjusts Marc's pocket square with the precision of a surgeon.

NATASHA

Stand up straight.

MARC-ANTHONY

I am standing up straight.

NATASHA

Stand up straighter. You're about to be on every television in the world.

MARC-ANTHONY

Mama, I'm on every television in the world every day. I'm in a yogurt commercial in Japan.

NATASHA

Not like this.

She stops fussing. Looks at him. Her baby boy, thirty-four years old, the most famous man alive.

NATASHA (CONT'D)

When he's done, they'll call you "sir" at the Tower. People twice your age will stand up when you walk in. And half of them will be praying you fail.

MARC-ANTHONY

Only half?

NATASHA

The other half will be helping.

MARC-ANTHONY

(smiling)

You're so encouraging. You should do motivational speaking.

NATASHA

(serious)

Marc-Anthony. I bend rules for a living. You know that. I taught you that.

MARC-ANTHONY

You taught me everything.

NATASHA

Then learn this one too. Never let them see you bend. Let them think you're the sweetest man in the room.

(beat)

Because you are. And that's the best disguise there is.

He kisses her forehead. She pats his cheek, twice, hard, like she did when he was little and about to go onstage.

NATASHA (CONT'D)

Go get your crown, baby.

The whole party has gathered below the grand staircase. DBC cameras on risers. Five hundred faces turned up toward the landing.

Victor stands at the top with Joan beside him. Below them, on the first landing, the family has been arranged the way families are arranged for photographs: Natasha and Robert, Jasmine and Peter, Elxa and Jeremy, Grace, Mallory, Martin.

And in the center, Marc-Anthony, with Lyric's hand in his.

VICTOR

Eighty-seven years ago, my father set four pages of type in a back room on Auburn Avenue. He had a few hundred dollars, a secondhand press, and a woman who believed in him enough to pay for it.

(beat)

That woman was my mother, Simone. And she's the reason every one of us is standing here tonight.

Applause. Joan squeezes his hand.

VICTOR (CONT'D)

They told my father a Black man couldn't own a newspaper in Georgia. He owned four. They told him a Black family couldn't own a ridge above the river. You're standing on it.

Applause, louder.

VICTOR (CONT'D)

My father built a newspaper. I built a company. My daughter Natasha built it into the most valuable enterprise the world has ever seen.

(turning to Natasha)

Thank you, baby.

Natasha raises her glass. Jasmine's smile does not move a millimeter.

VICTOR (CONT'D)

But a company is only a building until somebody decides who gets to hold the keys. And tonight, on my grandson's thirty-fourth birthday, I've decided.

The foyer goes utterly silent.

VICTOR (CONT'D)

Effective immediately, the board of The Donohue Company has appointed Marc-Anthony Bullock as its President and Chief Operating Officer.

A gasp ripples through the room. Then applause starts, uncertain at first, and builds into a roar. Cameras flash. Grace shrieks. Lyric jumps up and down.

Victor raises his hand. Silence again.

VICTOR (CONT'D)

And this morning, I signed over to him
eight hundred million Class B shares
of this company, with every vote that
comes with them.

(beat)

He is the first of my grandchildren to
hold a vote in this family's future.

A different sound now. Not a gasp. An intake of breath
from the people who understand what that means.

On the landing, Martin's hand closes around his champagne
flute.

VICTOR (CONT'D)

This family has a covenant. We take
care of what we've built. We give back
more than we take. And we pass the
crown to the one who will carry it the
farthest.

(looking at Marc)

Son. It's yours to carry.

Marc looks up at his grandfather. For once, he has nothing
funny to say.

MARC-ANTHONY

(barely audible)

Yes, sir.

The room explodes. Applause, cheers, the quartet striking
up a fanfare.

And on the landing, in the middle of the applause,
Martin's champagne flute SHATTERS in his gloved hand.

Glass rains onto the marble. Champagne runs down his
wrist. And through the black leather, slowly, a dark stain
spreads.

Blood.

Guests nearby turn. Mallory gasps. Jasmine grabs his arm.

JASMINE

Martin!

MARTIN

(calm, smiling)

It's nothing. Cheap glass.

Peter is already moving, pushing through the family toward his son. Martin holds up his bleeding hand to the room, still smiling.

MARTIN (CONT'D)

(loud, bright)

To my cousin!

The crowd, relieved, laughs and raises their glasses.

CROWD

To Marc-Anthony!

Across the landing, Marc and Martin lock eyes. Nobody else sees it. Marc isn't smiling anymore. Neither is Martin.

CUT TO:

20. INT. SUMMIT HOUSE - POWDER ROOM - NIGHT (10:08 PM)

Marble sink, gold fixtures. Martin sits on the vanity stool with his glove off. Peter kneels in front of him with a first-aid kit, cleaning the wound.

The gauze beneath is soaked through. Three of the eight black stitches have torn open.

PETER

These stitches were twenty hours old.

MARTIN

Then you did a bad job.

PETER

(tying off)

I did a perfect job. At two in the morning. In the middle of Sunday night. On my own son, who wouldn't tell me what he hit.

MARTIN

A wall.

PETER

Walls don't bruise like that.

MARTIN

This one did.

Peter looks up at him. Martin meets his gaze with perfect, polite calm.

PETER

Martin. If you're in trouble...

MARTIN

I'm not in trouble, Dad.

(standing, flexing the
fresh bandage)

I'm in line.

He pulls the ruined glove back on over the bandage and walks out. Peter kneels alone on the marble floor, holding a wad of bloody gauze.

He looks at it for a long moment.

Then he drops it into the trash and washes his hands for a long, long time.

CUT TO:

21. INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - ESTHER'S BEDROOM - NIGHT (10:10 PM)

Esther sits in the dark again, laptop open, the DBC live feed on screen. We hear Victor's voice, tinny and far away: "...President and Chief Operating Officer..."

On screen, Marc-Anthony stands on the staircase, stunned and golden.

Esther watches without moving.

On her nightstand, turned toward the bed, is a framed photo: two little girls, around six years old, in matching

Easter dresses, grinning with the same crooked grin.

Esther looks from the screen to the photo. From the photo to the screen.

Down the hall, the music has stopped. A door creaks. Small footsteps. Esther quickly angles the laptop away from the door.

EMMA (O.S.)
(sleepy, through the door)
Mom? Are you watching the Donohue thing?

ESTHER
(too quickly)
No, baby. Go to sleep.

VICTORIA (O.S.)
She's totally watching it.

EMMA (O.S.)
Shh!

Giggles. Footsteps retreating. A door closes.

Esther lets out a breath she's been holding for fourteen years.

She closes her eyes.

ESTHER
(barely a whisper)
Not yet.

She shuts the laptop.

CUT TO:

22. INT. SUMMIT HOUSE - VICTOR'S STUDY - NIGHT (10:30 PM)

The party roars on beyond the closed doors. Inside, quiet. Victor pours three fingers of fifty-year-old scotch into three glasses. Joan sits in a wingback chair. Marc stands in the middle of the room like a man who's just been hit by a very expensive truck.

VICTOR

Sit down before you fall down.

MARC-ANTHONY

I'm fine.

JOAN

You're swaying.

MARC-ANTHONY

It's the scotch.

VICTOR

You haven't had any.

MARC-ANTHONY

I'm anticipating it.

He sits. Victor hands him a glass.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)

Granddaddy. I didn't ask for this.

VICTOR

That's why you got it. Anybody who asks for a crown is exactly who shouldn't have one.

MARC-ANTHONY

Martin asked for it.

VICTOR

Martin's been asking since he was thirteen.

(beat)

Martin pushed you down my staircase on Christmas night. You think I didn't see it?

Marc goes very still.

MARC-ANTHONY

You told everybody it was an accident.

VICTOR

I told everybody what the family needed to hear. You broke your arm. He broke something worse in himself. I've been watching him ever since.

JOAN

Victor.

VICTOR

He needs to know, Joan. He's not a boy anymore.

(to Marc)

You have a good heart. The best in this family. That's why you'll carry it farther than any of us.

(beat)

But a good heart is also the first thing they'll try to cut out of you.

Marc looks down into his scotch. When he looks up, there's something in his eyes that neither of his grandparents has quite seen before. Calm. Clear. Old.

MARC-ANTHONY

They can try.

Victor studies him a long moment. Then he raises his glass.

VICTOR

To the future.

JOAN

To the family.

MARC-ANTHONY

(grinning, the boy again)

To the peacocks.

VICTOR

What peacocks?

JOAN
(sighing)
Your son sent peacocks.

VICTOR
(closing his eyes)
Of course he did.

A knock. The door opens. Natasha and Robert slip in, shoes in hand, both of them a little breathless from the dance floor.

NATASHA
There you are. I've been looking for my son. The President.

ROBERT
Chief Operating Officer. Say the whole title, Tasha. We paid for it.

VICTOR
You didn't pay for anything.

ROBERT
Emotionally, Victor. Emotionally I paid for it.

Marc laughs and stands. Robert pulls him into a hug and holds on a beat longer than usual.

ROBERT (CONT'D)
(low, just for Marc)
Proud of you. You know that?

MARC-ANTHONY
I know, Daddy.

ROBERT
(pulling back, back to business)
Now. As your attorney. Never sign anything your grandfather hands you without me reading it first.

VICTOR
Robert.

ROBERT

As his father, I stand by it.

Joan laughs, finally, and holds out her glass. Victor pours scotch for everyone.

They drink.

ACT SIX**23. EXT. SUMMIT HOUSE - MOTOR COURT - NIGHT (11:10 PM)**

The party is emptying out. Valets run. Guests stumble to cars, laughing. Somewhere in the east garden a peacock SCREAMS. Several guests scream back.

Elxa and Jeremy wait at the curb for the Tahoe. Jeremy's phone buzzes. He answers instantly.

JEREMY
(into phone)
Jackson... Say that again.

He listens. His face changes.

JEREMY (CONT'D)
Don't touch it. I'm on my way.

He hangs up.

ELXA
What?

JEREMY
The M.E. went back through his clothes. Sewn into the lining of that coat. A second phone. A burner.

ELXA
(beat)
Somebody sewed a phone into his coat.

JEREMY
Somebody who didn't want it found.

ELXA
Or somebody who did.

The Tahoe pulls up. Jeremy opens her door, then hesitates.

JEREMY
I'll take a squad car. You go home.

ELXA

I'm the Chief of Police, Jeremy. I don't go home.

JEREMY

(gently)

You do tonight. You're in a ball gown and you've had four glasses of your grandfather's champagne.

ELXA

Three.

JEREMY

Three and a half. I counted.

She wants to argue. She doesn't.

ELXA

Call me the second you know who he is.

JEREMY

You'll be the first.

He kisses her quickly and jogs off toward a waiting patrol car. Elxa stands alone in the cold under the blazing house.

At the top of the steps, Grace catches Marc by the sleeve before he can leave.

GRACE

Hey.

MARC-ANTHONY

Hey.

GRACE

I saw how you and Martin looked at each other up there.

MARC-ANTHONY

He cut his hand. I was concerned.

GRACE

(flat)

Uh-huh.

(beat)
Whatever that was. Whatever it turns
into. You call me first.

MARC-ANTHONY
Gracie. What are you going to do, sing
at him?

GRACE
I own a shovel, Marc-Anthony. I own a
very nice shovel. And I don't ask
questions.

He looks at his baby sister in her emerald gown and
diamonds, dead serious, and he pulls her into a hug.

MARC-ANTHONY
(into her hair)
I know you don't.

She lets go. He goes back for Lyric.

A Maybach pulls up for the Olsons. Peter opens the door
for Jasmine. She pauses, one foot in the car, and looks
back up at the blazing house.

JASMINE
Tomorrow morning, I'm going to see my
father.

PETER
Jasmine, let it breathe for one night.

JASMINE
I let it breathe for fifty-five years,
Peter.

(beat)
Tomorrow it's going to hear me.

She gets in. Martin slides in beside her without a word,
cradling his bandaged hand. The door shuts. The car glides
away into the dark.

Behind her, at the top of the steps, Marc walks Lyric out
to a waiting car, a sleepy thirteen-year-old slumped
against his side. Kane walks one step behind.

Elxa turns and watches the three of them go down the steps into the dark.

She doesn't know why she can't look away.

CUT TO:

24. INT. HARMONY'S APARTMENT - ADAMSVILLE - NIGHT (11:40 PM)

A small one-bedroom in southwest Atlanta. Film posters for movies that were never made. A secondhand desk. A space heater ticking in the corner.

Harmony, still in the black dress, kicks off her heels and sits down at the desk. She opens the worn laptop from her camera bag.

She logs in. The screen shows a sleek pink-and-black blog dashboard.

THE TEA KETTLE ATL.

Two point one million followers.

Harmony cracks her knuckles. And she begins to type. We see the words appear on screen as she writes them.

INSERT - LAPTOP SCREEN

The cursor blinks. Then the words appear:

"BLIND ITEM: Which ridge royal broke a champagne glass with his bare hand tonight when Granddaddy handed the crown to his cousin? Word is the blood matched his gloves. And an UPDATE on this morning's item: our Tuxedo Park princess stayed home AGAIN. Fourteen years of birthday invitations, fourteen no-shows. Some allergies run deep... #KettleIsOn #RidgeVsThePark"

BACK TO SCENE

Harmony reads it over. She hesitates over the second item. Her finger hovers over the delete key.

She thinks of Esther on the terrace: "It's genetic."

She leaves it in.

She clicks PUBLISH.

The post goes live. Within seconds the counters begin to spin. Likes. Shares. Comments. Hundreds. Thousands.

Her phone buzzes on the desk. A text. The name on the screen: ESTHER.

INSERT - HARMONY'S PHONE

ESTHER: "Did you see the Kettle??? 'Fourteen years.' Who COUNTS that?"

BACK TO SCENE

Harmony stares at the text. She glances at the laptop. Back at the phone.

She types with one thumb.

INSERT - HARMONY'S PHONE

HARMONY: "idk. weirdos"

BACK TO SCENE

She hits send, sets the phone face-down, and presses both hands over her face.

Harmony leans back in her chair in the ticking dark, watching the numbers climb, her face lit blue by the screen.

HARMONY
(softly, to herself)
Nobody takes me seriously.

(beat)
Everybody reads me.

CUT TO:

**25. INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S ESTATE - LYRIC'S ROOM - NIGHT
(11:52 PM)**

Dark. Lyric is asleep in her gala dress, on top of the covers, one shoe still on.

Marc eases the shoe off. Pulls a blanket over her. He picks up the small wrapped box from her nightstand, the gift from this morning, and sits on the floor beside the bed, back against the wall, the way he did every night when she was eight.

He unwraps it. Inside is a keychain: a small silver disk, engraved.

He turns it toward the moonlight.

INSERT - THE KEYCHAIN

Engraved in a child's careful choice of font: "WORLD'S OKAYEST UNCLE. JUST KIDDING. BEST."

BACK TO SCENE

Marc laughs silently, so hard his shoulders shake. He presses the keychain to his lips.

MARC-ANTHONY
(whisper)
Best one yet.

He kisses her forehead and slips out.

CUT TO:

26. INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S ESTATE - STUDY - NIGHT (11:58 PM)

A modern study, glass and walnut. Awards on floating shelves. Floor-to-ceiling windows look out over the dark ridge toward the distant, glittering towers of Atlanta.

Marc enters, loosening his bow tie. He pours nothing. He sits at his desk.

His phone lights up: a flood of notifications.
CONGRATULATIONS. PRESIDENT & COO. #HBDMarcAnthony. A news alert from Wall & Broad: DONOHUE NAMES BULLOCK PRESIDENT;

SHARES SURGE AFTER HOURS.

And one from The Tea Kettle ATL. He reads it. He smiles slightly at the first item. He frowns slightly at the second.

"...our Tuxedo Park princess stayed home AGAIN... fourteen no-shows..."

He sets the phone face-down.

He opens the bottom drawer of the desk and takes out something new: a leather notebook, dark blue, never opened. He uncaps a fountain pen, his grandfather's gift from his Yale graduation.

He looks out the window at the city, at the lights, at the whole sleeping country beyond them.

The clock on the desk changes: 11:59 PM.

He opens the notebook to the first page.

And in one steady stroke, he writes a single word.

INSERT - THE NOTEBOOK

In bold black ink: "2028."

BACK TO SCENE

Marc-Anthony Bullock sits back in his chair and looks at what he's written. He isn't smiling. He isn't laughing.

He looks like a man who has just decided the rest of his life.

HOLD on his face in the dark, the city burning bright beyond the glass.

FADE OUT.

END OF EPISODE #0001